

Operation: Icarus (Me)

Ever since joining Blackhand's crew, Baptiste had honed an alternate personality in the underworld as Solaris, becoming a more renowned figure every time he made an appearance. It was under this guise that he met a powerful syndicate run by two sisters who were called, Fortune's Sisters. His initial interaction with the group came about after Baptiste witnessed the group snatching children from the homes of their families due to failed debt repayments. Unable to stop them at the time without risking his cover getting blown, Baptiste watched the scenes unfold before him seething with anger and resolved himself to bring the group crumbling down. During his investigations, Baptiste uncovered a strange rumor amongst the people, Fortune's Sisters had built their power off a rare species that they had captured. The rumors also detailed that every once and a while, Fortune's Sisters would invite prestigious unaffiliated underworld figures to see said creature, and every time, the figures who attended, ended up blindly devoting themselves to the syndicate. It was from this rumor that Baptiste began to spread his name around the island, building his infamy under the guise of Solaris with the hopes of receiving an invite into the lion's den to destroy them from inside out.

After some time, Baptiste ended up receiving an invitation to a banquet hosted by Fortune's Sisters, his ticket in. Using the invitation, Baptiste infiltrated the banquet under the guise of Solaris, and upon entering, confirmed the rumors he had previously heard were indeed true. As it turned out, Fortune's Sisters had been holding a mermaid captive and been using her to farm materials to sell and use her song to charm people into joining them. Upon seeing the state of the mermaid, Baptiste was reminded of his days held in captivity, but repressed his anger as it was too early to take action. Going through the banquet, Baptiste watched as the song took hold of other participants' minds and when it became his turn to be seduced by the song, he was prepared and managed to resist, something only the mermaid took notice of. Upon noticing her realization, Baptiste gave a charming wink, seemingly seductive in the eyes of the members of Fortune's Sisters, but one of acknowledgement and secrecy to the mermaid. From this initial encounter, Baptiste then began operating within Fortune's Sisters as one of its members, only completing missions that did not bring harm to the common people and even sabotaging other members missions which went against his values.

Due to his excellent performance on these missions, and his counterparts continuous failures due to his sabotages, Baptiste was constantly rewarded for his success and each time he only asked for time with the mermaid, further entailing the narration that he was infatuated with her. It was from these meetings that Baptiste began to understand her story and how she ended up in a place like this. She spoke of how she was quite rebellious when she was free and wanted to enter the human world to have fun for a while when she learned of a masquerade ball a nearby kingdom was having. As she had just turned 30 as well, her tail had split allowing her to walk on land. However, the ball ended up being a cover up for what was truly going on in the kingdom, the nobles had become corrupt and Fortune's Sisters had already seeped their claws into the area. It

was halfway through the ball that the true nature of the event arose when drugs and cages began to enter the hall and one such cage was unveiled to hold a young female mermaid, a premium slave to nobles. With her rebellious personality and the nature of mermaids and their tight knit communities, she ended up attacking the organizers of the event to free the young mermaid. In the ensuing struggle, she eventually managed to free the young child, but in the process, she herself was captured and her identity as a mermaid was revealed. From that point on, the Fortune's Sisters had been holding her captive, doping her up with drugs and using her to expand their influence.

After hearing her full story and exchanging his own, and spending long enough in Fortune's Sisters to understand the dynamics of the organization, Baptiste organized a plan to free the mermaid and destroy the organization at the same time. It was on a day when most of the organization had been sent out on missions and even Baptiste had received one, but instead of leaving to carry it out, he dispatched the squad he was given for the mission and covertly returned to the organization to release the mermaid. Blinded by the success of his mission up to the point, Baptiste hadn't noticed how easy getting the mermaid from her captivity had been and once they exited the organization, they were met with the full force of Fortune's Sisters who had predicted everything. A bloody battle then ensued as the culmination of all the rage Baptiste had controlled until now let loose as he did his best to protect the weakened mermaid. With an overwhelming number of enemies, a second and third surge in his strength using his devil fruit then lunarian abilities would fall short of eradicating the full force of Fortune's Sisters, and Baptiste eventually exhausted himself and began to be overwhelmed. It was at this point that a melodic tune began to spread through the battlefield as the mermaid had begun to will herself into acting as her song began to drive the members of Fortune's Sisters mad and revitalized Baptiste in the process. Thinking the situation was now winnable, Baptiste was disheartened when he realized the song was killing the mermaid as well. After being weakened for so long, never receiving proper treatment, and using her abilities for the Fortune's Sisters for so long, she began to succumb to her injuries.

Upon realizing this, Baptiste pleaded for her to stop, but she argued back that her time was coming to an end soon anyways, and if she could use the last of that time to ensure Baptiste could escape, then she could happily rest. Her final wish was that if one day, Baptiste were to find a mermaid, he tell them her story and even gave him a heirloom of hers reminding him that since mermaids are a close community, if he were to find one and show them this, the rest would fall into place. With her final wishes relayed, she then marched towards the Fortune's Sisters forces, song never faltering in tune, hair blowing in the wind, with the sun setting in the distance, leaving a silhouette Baptiste would never forget as he regrettably withdrew from the area, a tear falling from his eye.

Later on, a newspaper would then be released detailing the events of the island, and Baptiste's identity as Solaris was painted to be a terrorist who had done everything Baptiste had known Fortune's Sisters were responsible for, and the mermaid, given the name "Wailing Siren," was named as an accomplice who Fortune's Sisters had killed, ending the torment the two had enacted. The newspaper also detailed how Baptiste had fled leaving the mermaid alone and thus titled the article, *Icarus*, as without the influence of Baptiste, the mermaid may not have ended up with such a fate.

Reading the article and knowing the true nature of what unfolded, Baptiste was left in a turmoil for a while, neglecting his other operations. It wasn't until Blackhand snapped him out of it with a stern talking accompanied by a beating that Baptiste focused on what he experienced rather than learned, accepting the outcome and choosing to follow the last wishes of one of the first true friends he made since his own freedom. It was also around this time Blackhand had given Baptiste a new mission, to rescue another like him, and it was this mission that further reinforced his resolve as he created a new alias, one in dedication and honor of the mermaid to replace his previous one of Solaris, *Masquerade*.